Philosophy of Religion

Religionsfilosofi

Harald Høffding

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Alte dubitat, qui altius credit.

(He doubts more deeply who believes more deeply.)

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Chapter 1

Problem and Procedure

ou lyseis agnoōn ton desmon.
ARISTOTLE.
(One cannot untie a knot without knowing where it is bound).

1. By *philosophy of religion* one could mean either a thinking that springs from religion and builds on religion, or a thinking that takes religion as its object. It is in this latter sense that the term shall be taken here. The thinking that springs from and builds on religion itself belongs to the subject matter of the philosophy of religion and should not be called philosophy of religion.

By religion we think first of all of a state of mind in which feeling and need, fear and hope, enthusiasm and devotion play a larger role than reflection and inquiry, and in which intuition and image hold more sway than investigation and reasoning. To be sure, again and again in the religious life there will arise an involuntary need to give an account of one's condition and of its content—of the worth of one's motives and the validity of one's thoughts. But the religious thinking that thus arises does not pose the religious problem in a decisive way. Its problems arise within religion, but religion itself does not become a problem. No other starting point is yet recognized than religion itself; in any case other starting points are so subordinate in relation to religion that they do not acquire decisive significance. Of this kind is religious thinking in those times in which religion is everything on the spiritual plane. These are the classical times of religion: partly the great times of origins, in which religion with all the power of originality draws all strength and interest to itself; partly the great times of organization, in which all existing culture is shaped or bent into obedience under the highest religious ideas. In such classical times there is a

great unity, or at least a great harmony, in the domain of spiritual life. Christianity had such a classical time in the age of the primitive Christian community, and later in the great organizational period at the height of the Middle Ages. A religious problem forms only when other sides of spiritual life—science and art, morality and social life—begin to free themselves and to appear with the claim of having independent value. They then judge religion from their points of view and by their standards, whereas religion in its classical times either simply ignored them—as in the times of origins—or—as in the times of organization—valued them from its own point of view and by its own standard, so that the question became whether these two different evaluations could be brought into mutual harmony.—There must be definite historical conditions present before the religious problem can be posed in a decisive way. It is, if one will, only in unhappy times that a religious problem exists. For this problem is the expression of a spiritual disharmony: the different elements of spiritual life no longer work together in so unified a way as before; they lead in different directions, among which one must perhaps ultimately choose. But then both the necessity and the possibility of an investigation are also present.

That religion is made into a problem will be offensive to many. But thought must have the right to investigate everything, once it has awakened, and only thought itself can mark out its boundaries. Who else should mark out its boundaries? He who perceives no problem has of course no reason to think; but neither has he any reason to prevent others from thinking. He who fears losing his spiritual support must keep away. No one wishes to rob the poor man of his only lamb—but then the poor man must not unnecessarily come dragging it along the highway and demand that traffic be stopped on his account. Experience shows, moreover, that it is rather the oxen than the lambs that loudly announce themselves with their indignation in season and out of season (especially out of season). It is not so much the genuinely poor in spirit as the stiff and blustering dogmatists who take offense when free inquiry claims the right to stir on the religious plane as on any other.

The investigation I wish to undertake here addresses itself neither to those who are finished nor to those who are fearful. The finished are found in every camp, not least among the so-called "freethinkers"—a class of people who, like the "Worms" in Linnaeus's system, can be characterized only by negative predicates, because the class is supposed to encompass so many different forms. The finished are in possession of a definite negative or positive solution to the religious problem and have thereby lost the sense for further thinking about it. The fearful dare not think

about it.—Rather, the investigation addresses itself to those who are *becoming*. "One who is becoming will always be grateful"—no matter in which direction his becoming goes.

Philosophy is, as is well known, richer in ideas, perspectives, and discussions than in definitive results, and the philosopher would often be in a sorry state if he did not believe that the constant striving after truth belongs to the highest spiritual values, which it is the task of all true religion to uphold. Even if we could learn nothing else from a philosophy-of-religion investigation, we could perhaps learn something about the causes of the strife that rages over religious questions, and about this strife's significance for the development of spiritual life. And should the religious problem prove insoluble, we might perhaps learn why it is insoluble.

2. The philosophy of religion should not proceed from a finished philosophical system. In a certain sense all thinking must be systematic, for "system" literally means "that which stands together," and it is an inexorable demand placed on our thoughts that they must be able to "stand together" with one another. There is an inner coherence and consistency which in every domain is the ultimate mark of truth, and which must therefore also be required in the domain of the philosophy of religion. But the philosophy-of-religion enterprise will be most fruitful where religion and its phenomena are not placed in relation to an already completed philosophical conception, but are illuminated by a philosophizing that is itself in the process of investigating whether a completion is possible at all. The task is to discuss religion's relation to spiritual life. Religion is itself a kind of or form of spiritual life, and it is judged rightly only when seen in its relation to other kinds or forms. It is no alien standard that is thereby applied to religion. For there is a service from which no spiritual power—even if it appears under the greatest names—can exempt itself, namely to serve the deep and rich development of spiritual life. The philosophy-of-religion task will therefore above all be to find the means for investigating whether religion, under the conditions of our spiritual culture, can continue to render such service. In solving, or better: in treating this task, the philosophy of religion cannot come equipped with other presuppositions than those which every other science brings to the treatment of its subject. Very often it will surely be compelled to declare that there are questions that cannot be answered, because the conditions in the spiritual domain are more complex and more diverse than positive and negative dogmatists suppose. Yet it is not without significance that the problems are discussed. The conscious insight into the impossibility of a solution

(*docta ignorantia*) naturally invites one to investigate whether it is then so absolutely necessary that a solution be found. In addition, one's eye will be sharpened for the particular conditions under which our spiritual culture lives, conditions which would probably not continue to persist, just as they even now do not exert equal influence on all personalities.

A philosophy-of-religion investigation can suitably be arranged so as to consist of an epistemological, a psychological, and an ethical part.

In its classical times, religion satisfies all of humankind's spiritual needs, including its drive for knowledge. Religious ideas then contain for human beings the explanation of existence in its entirety and in its individual parts. But when an independent science has developed, another kind of understanding or explanation appears alongside the religious one, and the question becomes whether these two kinds are compatible. Possibly the situation might be that the new, scientific mode of explanation increasingly replaces the religious explanation where particulars are concerned, but that it cannot be applied to existence considered as a whole—to what one customarily calls the "first" or the "last" questions. Then one must discuss whether religion is able to solve the riddles that science cannot solve. If it should then turn out that religious conceptions, whether with respect to the whole or to the particular, cannot help with anything that could rightly be called understanding or explanation, then one must raise the question what significance these conceptions can still have.

This last question leads from the epistemological philosophy of religion to the psychological. For if religious conceptions no longer have cognitive value, the value they might possess must consist in being expressions of sides of the life of the soul other than the intellectual. An attempt must then be made to describe the religious life of the soul, especially the relation of conceptions to religious experience and religious feeling. Through this it will become apparent that religion in its innermost nature has to do not with the understanding of existence but with the *evaluation* of it, and that religious conceptions express the relation in which factual existence, as we know it, stands to that which for us gives life its highest value. The core of religion is—according to the hypothesis to which we are led—a faith in the persistence of value in existence. This faith appears in great, vivid images in the popular religions, especially in the highest among them. Even in those who stand outside every popular religion, such a faith may stir, even though it does not here take definite shape.

The transition from psychological to ethical philosophy of religion is naturally motivated by the question: what ethical value does it have that one believes in the persistence of value? Ethics concerns the production of values, and the possibility cannot be dismissed that the work of producing values leaves no time and no strength for living in the thought of their persistence. The ethical philosophy of religion forms a parallel to the epistemological. In its classical times, religion directly and indirectly determines the evaluation of all actions and all conditions of life. The religious problem arises on this point when an independent ethics has developed that seeks, by its own path, the grounding and motivation for the evaluation of human actions. And on this point the problem is posed in the sharpest and most pressing way, for the ultimate standard for judging religion must belong to the ethical domain, where the final reckoning of the spiritual account takes place.—

Within the framework here indicated, we should be able to find room for all essential aspects of the religious problem. I wish to treat this problem not only with the intellectual interest that is aroused by a great and comprehensive subject, but also in the mood that comes from the consciousness of standing before a spiritual form of life in which the human race through millennia has deposited some of its deepest and most inward experiences.

3. Before we enter upon the individual parts of the philosophy of religion, it will be useful to give a somewhat more detailed characterization of the content of the religious problem.

In the Protestant world it is fairly generally acknowledged that one must distinguish between knowledge and faith. The Catholic Church does not acknowledge this distinction in its full extent and therefore does not acknowledge any religious problem in the intellectual domain. It maintains that God's existence can be proved by the paths that Thomas Aquinas, supported by Aristotle, pointed out, and it has even declared it a matter of faith to accept that these proofs suffice. The tradition from the great time of the Middle Ages, when "one did not doubt and was therefore nearer to the truth" (to use a sentence from one of Thomas Aquinas's modern biographers), is continually upheld, and it is not acknowledged that a disharmony has really entered into spiritual life. The distinction between knowledge and faith concedes that such a disharmony is present—that the unity of spiritual life is broken. Is this distinction itself then only a station on the way, in that development will lead to an elimination of all religion from spiritual life, because only that can endure which can enter into a harmonious relation with the other elements of life?—Whether one now

assumes that it is only the classical time of religion that is past, or that its time is altogether past, the question cannot be set aside whether spiritual value is lost in the process of dissolution that has set in, or whether a replacement can be found for the spiritual unity and self-containment that was lost. This consideration alone shows that the question of the persistence of value is an essential aspect of the religious problem, whatever solution one inclines toward. It is not least from this side that philosophy in the last century and a half (from the time of Rousseau, Lessing, and Kant onward) has treated the religious problem. Both Romantics and Positivists have been attentive to this aspect of it.—It must of course be remembered that even if one could show that no spiritual energy was lost in the dissolution of religion, it does not follow that the energy would under the new conditions receive as valuable an application as in the classical times of religion. In the spiritual domain no less than in the material, the conservation of energy is not without further ado the same as the persistence of value. Energy can persist without value persisting, while the reverse cannot well be imagined, since energy in and of itself will be a condition for the persistence and development of what is valuable. Many freethinkers proceed without further ado from the assumption that human life will become more powerful and richer when religion falls away—an assumption that is not self-evident and that rests on the presupposition that psychic equivalents are present—equivalents both in terms of value and in terms of energy. The task will then be to demonstrate these equivalents and thereby establish the persistence of value. But it is a great question and an essential aspect of the religious problem whether such equivalents can be demonstrated.—Moreover, the problem of the persistence of value will also arise within the Church, for religion and the religious life undergo constant changes; and the question becomes whether the values from the classical times of religion persist through these changes—e.g., whether primitive Christianity, both in terms of value and in terms of energy, is preserved in the Christianity of our day. In its sharpest form this problem has appeared in the assertion: "the Christianity of the New Testament no longer exists."—

But the religious problem concerns not only the persistence of value within the human world. It raises not only a psychological but also a cosmological question, namely about the relation between that which stands as the highest value for human beings and the whole of existence. Is there any connection between values and the laws and forces of existence? Are these laws and forces perhaps even ultimately determined by the highest values? Or can we perhaps not ascribe any validity to

the concept of value beyond the domain of human life?

The hypothesis that will later (in the psychological philosophy of religion) be sought to be grounded holds that the proposition of the persistence of value is the actual religious axiom, which is expressed in different ways in the different religions and at the different religious standpoints. The religious problem thus concerns the question whether this axiom can really be taken to hold. And at the same time this axiom, insofar as it expresses the fundamental thought of all religion, can be used as a standard for the consistency and significance of the individual religion or the individual religious standpoint. Finally—as already noted—the relation between ethics and religion can, with the help of this axiom, be expressed in a very simple way: how does faith in the persistence of value relate to the work of finding, producing, and preserving values?—

If the proposition of the persistence of value were to be discussed in its full scope, the discussion would become interminable, and clear starting points for conducting it would soon be lacking. I therefore emphasize at once the limits within which my investigation will move, and which must be kept in mind throughout all that follows.—When I attempt to show that the said proposition is the fundamental thought of all religion, this attempt will not have failed because it turns out that no religion expresses the proposition with clarity and consistency. It will be sufficient if an explicit need or tendency to hold fast to this fundamental thought can be demonstrated, so that the standard for the evaluation of religions in their mutual relations becomes the degree to which they are able to articulate and carry through the proposition.—When the persistence of value is spoken of, this could be understood to mean that value does not vanish, but that there is constantly value in existence, whether it decreases or increases or alternates between decrease and increase. But I understand the expression *the persistence of value* in analogy with the expression *the conservation of energy*, such that the proposition asserts a constant persistence of value through all changes of form. It will perhaps be necessary here to distinguish between potential and actual value, just as one distinguishes between potential and actual energy, and the one distinction is just as clear and just as justified as the other.—But the persistence of value through all changes of form and despite the difference between possibility and actuality is nonetheless only a minimum. It may be maintained that the mere persistence of value is not satisfying and actually contains a contradiction, since value can persist only by growing, since mere repetition dulls, while on the other hand change is valuable only when it brings enhancement. That

an increase of value does not conflict with the conservation of energy needs no further demonstration; the increase of value presupposes only a new and more perfect application of energy, not an increase of energy as a whole. It is for the sake of simplicity that I limit the investigation to the persistence of value. And it will also turn out that religious consciousness has at bottom limited itself to this as well. The persistence of value will present us with difficulties and tasks enough, even if we do not enter into everything that lies in the unavoidable consequence that value can persist only if it increases. Yet we must not forget that this consequence is present.—Finally, when the persistence of value is under discussion, one might ask: which value and how much value? I enter into these questions only insofar as the difference between the different religions and religious standpoints essentially depends on the different answers they give to them. It is clear that the proposition of the persistence of value can be accepted whatever answers one gives. The hypothesis that the persistence of value is the fundamental religious proposition is not shaken by the fact that the different religions and religious standpoints diverge greatly from one another with respect to the character and extent of the valuable in whose persistence they believe.

Value is the property of something that it brings about a real satisfaction or can become the means to such. Value can therefore be immediate or mediate. Immediate value we seek to hold fast when it is given, and to produce when it is not given. We thus make it our end. That we make something an end presupposes, conversely, that we have an experience or a supposition of its immediate value. Mediate value belongs to that which serves the attainment of an end—that is, of an immediate value. Mediate value need not be potential value. For what serves as a means for attaining something of immediate value itself acquires value in our eyes, even though its value stands as derived. There are all possible transitions between mediate and immediate value, and through the shifting of motives the former passes over into the latter, so that what at first had value only as a means now acquires value as an end. Potential value, on the other hand, often means only the possibility that something will acquire value as a means—that is, the possibility of mediate value.—Which values are experienced and therefore acknowledged at the different standpoints will depend on the different character of those standpoints. It is a being's nature that determines its need, and it is its need that determines what acquires value for it. The religious axiom thus shows the necessity of a religion's character being determined by the nature and need of the human beings who profess it. For one cannot seriously

believe in the persistence of values that one does not know at least approximately from one's own experience.—

It is to Kant's philosophy that we owe the independence of the problem of value from the problem of knowledge. He taught us to distinguish between evaluation and explanation. That this distinction cannot, however, be a complete opposition is clear from the fact that it must depend on the laws and forces of existence whether something can acquire value for us and whether we can make the valuable into an end that can be realized. The religious problem can therefore not be separated from the other philosophical problems, even though it is most advantageous to treat it by itself. It presents a clear analogy with the other problems. The fundamental philosophical problem concerns the continuity of existence in its relation to the special and individual forms of existence. And if the hypothesis that the proposition of the persistence of value is the religious axiom turns out to be well-founded, then the religious problem concerns the continuity of existence from a distinctive point of view and thus falls under the fundamental problem as a special form of it.

Chapter 2

Epistemological Philosophy of Religion

2.1 Understanding

2.1.1 Causal Explanation

2.1.2 The World of Space

2.1.3 The Course of Time

2.2 Concluding Thoughts

2.3 Thought and Image

Chapter 3

Psychological Philosophy of Religion

3.1 Religious Experience and Religious Faith

3.1.1 Religious Experience

3.1.2 Religious Faith

3.2 The Development of Religious Ideas

3.2.1 Religion as Drive

3.2.2 Polytheism and Monotheism

3.2.3 Religious Experience and Tradition

3.2.4 The Scientific Conclusion of the Psychology of Religion

3.3 Dogmas and Symbols

3.4 The Proposition of the Persistence of Value

3.4.1 More Precise Determination of the Proposition of the Persistence of Value and of its Relation to Experience

3.4.2 Psychological-Historical Discussion of the Proposition of the Persistence of Value

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3.5 The Principle of Personality

Chapter 4

Ethical Philosophy of Religion

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4.2 Religion as a Form of Spiritual Culture

4.2.1 Psychological Considerations

4.2.2 Sociological Considerations

4.3 Primitive Christianity and Modern Christianity

4.4 We Live on Realities

Notes